

Blue-footed booby

Sula nebouxii

large feet fully
webbed across
four toes



The male blue-footed booby relies on his colorful feet to impress potential mates. The blue color is enhanced by pigments that come from a regular supply of fresh fish. The brighter the feet, the better nourished the male is, showing how good a provider he will be for offspring. Females tend to mate with younger males, as the brightness declines with age. Closely related to gannets, and more loosely to pelicans and cormorants, boobies have broad webbing across all four toes.

Survival of the fittest

About half of the world's blue-footed booby population is centered in the Galapagos Islands, although few young have been reared there recently. This is mainly due to a drop in the sardine population on which the booby feeds almost exclusively. The breeding season is short and the female lays two or three eggs, which hatch several days apart.

When there is enough food, the different sizes of chicks allow them all to be fed without much rivalry. Should food be scarce, the older, bigger chick kills its siblings and is more likely to survive. If more than one survives, the smaller chick will have as good a chance of becoming a productive adult.

- ↔ 30–35 in (75–90 cm)
- ⚖ 3–4 lb (1.3–1.8 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Sardines, other fish
- 🏠



▷ COURTSHIP DANCE

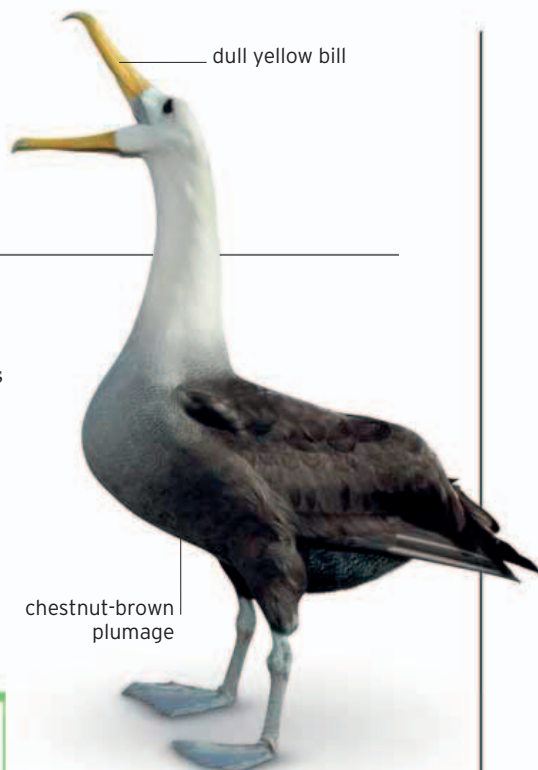
Courting blue-footed boobies show off the brilliance of their webbed feet, lifting them alternately in a ritualized, waddling dance.



Waved albatross

Phoebastria irrorata

The only tropical albatross, the waved albatross, breeds on the Galapagos Islands and feeds off the coast of Ecuador and Peru. It forages up to 60 miles (100 km) from its nest, where fish are found close to the surface. Waved albatrosses use their long, slender wings to exploit air currents to travel far with little effort.



- ↔ 34–37 in (86–93 cm)
- ⚖ 7–9 lb (3–4 kg)
- ⊗ Critically endangered
- 🐟 Fish, squid, crustaceans
- 🏠
- 📍 Galapagos Islands

△ CALLING OUT FOR A MATE

Albatrosses mate for life after an elaborate courtship ritual involving a precise sequence of moves, such as circling and bowing their bills.

Woodpecker finch

Camarhynchus pallidus

Finches in the Galapagos Islands have evolved into 15 distinct species, each with a different feeding strategy. In wet periods, the woodpecker finch feeds on abundant insects. However, in the hot, dry season it finds half its food by using a special tool—one of very few birds to do so. It wields a fine twig or cactus spine to remove grubs from crevices in bark or from tunnels bored into wood. The finch tests several tools and chooses the right one for the task, at times even snapping a twig to shorten it and make it more effective. It then goes on to use its favorite tool at several sites.



△ BILL EXTENDER

The woodpecker finch can use its bill to find grubs, but using a long spine means it can probe more deeply.

- ↔ 6 in (15 cm)
- ⚖ 11/16–1 1/16 oz (20–31 g)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🐛 Insects, larvae
- 🏠
- 📍 Galapagos Islands